

Session 30: From Folly to Wisdom in Relationships

Key Takeaways

- If we submit ourselves to the influence of the Spirit, we will be filled with the life of the new creation.

The Challenge To Live Wisely: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 5:15-25

Three Contrasts

Contrast 1

¹⁵ Therefore, watch carefully how y'all walk,
a **not as unwise** ,
b **but as wise** ,
¹⁶ redeeming the time, for the days are evil.

Contrast 2

¹⁷ Because of this,
a' **don't be foolish** ,
b' **but discern what is the will of the Lord** .

Contrast 3

a" ¹⁸ And **don't be drunk with wine**, which is recklessness;
b" **but be filled by the Spirit** ,

Spirit Influences 1-4

¹⁹ **speaking** to each other in psalms, hymns, and spiritual poems,
creating poems and **singing** in y'all's hearts to the Lord,
²⁰ **giving thanks** always to God the Father for all things in the name of our Lord Jesus Messiah,
²¹ **submitting** to one another in reverence of the Messiah,

Two Concrete Examples of Mutual Submission

²² wives to their husbands
as to the Lord ...

²⁵ husbands, be loving your wives,
as the Messiah loved the church ...

Ephesians 5:15-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

5:15-18: Three Contrasts

Paul here creates a triad of opposites, exploring the contrast between the old humanity and the new. Notice how all three revolve around the theme of wisdom, discernment, and outside influences.

1. Unwise/Wise: This is classic wisdom vocabulary from the Hebrew wisdom literature (especially Proverbs). Wisdom begins with the fear of the Lord (see [Prov. 5:21](#) where this becomes explicit), which is recognizing my capacities and limits as a human and living under the guidance and authority of one wiser and greater than myself.
2. Foolish/Discerning: Foolishness here is about the inability to discern the right way to be a human, a lack of intuition of why I exist and what my life is for. Discernment is about an ability to intuit what God would want in any given situation because my life has been shaped by his love and wisdom.
3. Drunk with wine/Filled with the Spirit: This is not a comparison of similarity, so that one should be “drunk with the Spirit” instead of wine. All three pairs are contrasting opposites, and this one is about contrasting influences. The outside influence of wine disintegrates your ability to make wise choices and discern God’s will. The outside influence of the Spirit fills you. But with what?

“Be Filled by the Spirit”

Greek note: Paul does not technically say “be filled with/of the Spirit,” as if the Spirit is the content of the filling. That requires the verb *πληρωω* and an accusative or genitive noun, as in [Acts 2:4](#) “full of the Spirit” (see also [Acts 4:8, 31](#); [9:17](#); [13:9](#); or [Phil. 1:11](#)). Rather, the use of this verb with the preposition “with” (*πληρωω* and *ἐν*) is regularly used to mark the agent of the filling, not the content, “be filled up by means of X.”

If the Spirit is here the agent of the filling, the content of the filling must be inferred. And Paul has given us plenty of clues in the preceding letter as to what God’s people are to be filled with.

Ephesians 1:22-23 NASB*

²² ... the church, ²³ which is his body, that which is filled up by the one who fills all things in all things.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ephesians 2:21-22 ESV*

²¹ The entire building ... grows into a holy temple in the Lord, ²² in whom you are built together into a dwelling place of God by means of the Spirit.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ephesians 3:16-17, 19 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ that you might be strengthened through the Spirit in your inner human, ¹⁷ that the Messiah might dwell in your hearts ... ¹⁹ to know the love of the Messiah, so that you might be filled unto all the fullness of God.

Ephesians 4:10 Instructor's Translation

The one who descended is also the one who ascended above all the heavenly realms, in order that he might fill all things.

Ephesians 4:13 NASB*

until we all attain ... unto the measure of the stature of the fullness of the Messiah.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"In the light of these earlier instances of the 'fullness' language, then, we conclude that the content with which believers have been (or are being) filled is the fullness of (the triune) God or of Christ. No other text in Ephesians (or elsewhere in Paul) focuses specifically on the Holy Spirit as the content of this fullness. It is better, then, to understand 5:18 in terms of the Spirit's mediating the fullness of God and Christ to believers ... To be admonished, 'Be filled by the Spirit', then, means that Paul's readers are urged to let the Spirit change them more and more into the image of God and Christ, a notion which is consistent with Pauline theology elsewhere."

O'Brien, Peter T. (1999). *The Letter to the Ephesians (The Pillar New Testament Commentary)*. Eerdmans. 391.

Ephesians 5:18-21: Four Manifestations of the Spirit's Influence

Every one of these four verbs indicates the results of the Spirit's influence, and they are all related to the common life of the worshiping community.

- "Speaking to each other in songs": This likely refers to the worship gathering, where Christians sang their theology (remember Eph. 5:14) and worldview into reality.
- "Singing ... in your hearts to the Lord": Poetry and song as an expression of loyalty, rapture, and spiritual connection to God has deep roots in the Jewish tradition (via the Psalms) and morphed into the Jesus movement, forming the heartbeat of their corporate worship.
- "Giving thanks for all things": This too is related to the corporate nature of the church's life, where people from all stations of life come together to share their stories and experiences of the Messiah's love and presence with them in their daily lives.
- "Submitting to one another out of reverence for the Messiah."

Reflection Question

In Ephesians 5:16, Paul uses the Greek word *exagorazo*, which can be translated as "liberate the time." As the new humanity, what does it mean to liberate the time?